

Dürer

The greatest figure of Northern Renaissance art, Albrecht Dürer (1471–1528) was a German printmaker, painter and writer. The son of a Nuremberg goldsmith, he became the first artist to produce self-portraits at different stages of his life and one of the first to experiment with etching, raising woodcut and engraving techniques to new levels of artistry. He also travelled widely. In 1490, he visited Cologne and the Netherlands, and he established the practice of artists visiting Rome and Florence as part of their artistic education. In Venice, he met Bellini and saw the work of Mantegna and Antonio del Pollaiuolo (c.1432–98). He blended many Italian ideas with those of northern Europe.

Dürer's woodcuts are often called his 'master prints', and revolutionized the potential of the medium. Sold across Europe, they established his reputation and influence while he was still in his twenties. His vast body of work includes altarpieces, religious works, portraits and engravings, and he wrote treatises on principles of mathematics, perspective and proportion.



Dürer, *Self-portrait*, c.1500